



When Sony first introduced its TPS-L2 personal audio in 1979, it created a sensation in the world of music. After some false starts, the name 'Walkman' was bestowed upon it, primarily because it was a cassette-based portable music device that could be easily carried with you wherever you go.

Over a decade later, Fraunhofer revolutionised the way music was recorded by developing the MP3 format. This not only reduced file sizes drastically but provided decent sound quality. The emergence of the Internet fuelled the success of this format because it allowed one to swap music files online, with ease.

The market for portable music players continued to be dominated by Walkman till a couple of years ago, but things are changing. The

technology employed in MP3 players has improved tremendously and we now get crisper sound, extended battery life because of the absence of moving parts in solid-state MP3 players and large storage space for songs.

Since MP3 players are portable devices, you'll need to keep a few things in mind while buying one. Ergonomics play as important a role in the buying decision as do features. Easy portability, convenient placement of buttons, and usability, are hot; bulky size, tiny buttons and menu navigation that needs a reference guide are not.

Buttons should be ideally on the front panel, and should be within easy reach. These days, MP3 players actually sport a whole range of new features, putting them into the category of hybrid devices rather than pure music players. Companies like Casio and Apacer have even built MP3 players into watches and USB drives.

The market is flooded with such devices, so it's critical for you to decide early on whether you want a plain-vanilla MP3 player, or a gizmo that comes with all the bells and whistles.

The menu structure should be simple and the functions accessible with minimal clicking. Some solid-state players don't come with an LCD screen—a basic requirement of any MP3 player. Turn a deaf ear to such obsolete players, which are still available in the market and sold to unwary buyers.

A robust earphone is important because it is the termination point in the audio chain. If it does not deliver good audio quality, the entire experience is lost. As far as portability is concerned, go in for smaller, lightweight devices.

Warranty is important in the case of portable devices, because they are going to be used while travelling or on the move. Chances of damage or malfunction are high, so the better the warranty the more faith you can rest in the brand. The same is true for after-sales support—the more outlets in a large number of cities and towns, the better.

## Market Overview

Creative, Sony and Philips are some well-known brands available in the market, along with cheaper Chinese counterparts like the NAPA-DAV, which retails for under Rs 5,750. Solid-state MP3 players cost around Rs 8,000 to 15,000, depending on the memory and features offered (LCD screen, volume control on headphones etc). This is at least 5-7 times costlier than normal CD MP3 players that retail for as little as Rs 3,000. Solid-state MP3 players are more expensive than CD MP3 players because their storage media is more expensive.

Solid-state MP3 players have a memory limitation—they come with a memory card, which is a costly means of storage. CD MP3 players, on the other hand, offer very long playtime because a 700 MB CD, which is now available for as little as Rs 10, can easily store 100-125 songs of 6-7 minutes in length.

CD MP3 players are bulkier and much heavier than solid-state players. The fidelity they offer is also not as great as that of the solid-state players.



## Buying tips for MP3 Player

You should check out the features first before buying any MP3 player. Given below are some features that you should look for:

- See if the player has support for more than one format, e.g. MP3 and WMA.
- The player should have a big enough LCD screen with backlit function, so you can read the information even in the dark.
- The buttons should be ideally placed so that if you have to operate a player that's buckled to your belt (or is in your pocket) you can do so without having to unbuckle or remove it.
- A rechargeable battery is a must, or the device will need frequent battery changes if used regularly.
- A sturdy carry case is very important, as any scratch or pressure on the LCD screen can harm this delicate device.
- Go in for a good set of earphones. The earphones need to reproduce sound faithfully.
- Make sure the MP3 player is covered under warranty for at least a year.
- The Line-out if present is definitely an added advantage as you can plug your MP3 Player to a music system.
- Upgradable memory is preferable to a fixed memory with no upgrade option.
- See that electronic shock protection of at least 100 seconds is provided with CD-MP3 player.

